US CIVIL WAR

CHARLESTON HARBOR



Date April 7, 1863
Forces Union: 7 monitors, 2 ironclads; Confederacy: none
Losses Union: 1 ironclad sunk

Location Charleston, South Carolina

In preparation for an attack upon the Confederate port of Charleston, Rear Admiral Samuel Francis du Pont's South Atlantic Blockading Squadron attempted to overcome the defenses of Charleston harbor by naval bombardment. Seven monitors and the ironclads *New Ironsides* and *Keokok* crossed the harbor bar on April 6, 1863, but poor visibility delayed the attack until the following morning. The Confederate defenses were excellently prepared. The channel into the harbor was blocked with obstacles and "torpedoes" (mines), while the gunners in Fort Sumter and Fort Multrie had taken measures to ensure that their fire was accurate and deadly. The monitor *Weehawken* was first to open fire on the forts with her Dahlgren guns, but she was soon taking hits on her armor, as well as having a torpedo explode beneath her. The unfortunate *Keokuk* found herself swept into the van on the flood tide. Her experimental armor (she was dubbed a "tinclad") was quickly holed. In all, the shore batteries fired 2,200 shots, achieving 440 hits, while the ships only managed to fire 154 shots before retiring for the day. *Keokuk* sank the following morning and the assault on the forts was abandoned.

US CIVIL WAR

ALABAMA VS KEARSARGE



Date June 19, 1864
Forces Confederacy: 1 steam sloop; Union: 1 steam sloop
Losses Confederacy: 1 ship sunk; Union: none

Location Off Cherbourg, France

The Confederate steam sloop *Alabama* was a highly successful commerce raider. Commanded by Captain Raphael Semmes, she sank more than 60 merchant ships. On June 14, 1864 she was trapped in the French port of Cherbourg by the Union sloop *Kearsarge* under Captain John Winslow. Five days later Semmes boldly came out to fight. The engagement lasted 70 minutes. The two ships steamed in opposite directions in narrowing circles, pounding one another with shot and shell. *Kearsarge* was armored with iron chains; *Alabama* was not. Holed and taking water, *Alabama* struck shortly before sinking. Semmes was among the 38 men saved by a private yacht.

THE BATTLE OF MOBILE BAY

US CIVIL WAR



THE BATTLE OF MOBILE BAY

Date	August 5, 1864
Location	Mobile Bay, Gulf of Mexico
Result	Union victory

COMBATANTS

UNION	CONFEDERACY
COMMANDERS	
David Farragut	**Franklin Buchanan**
FORCES	
Ships: 4 monitors, 14 wooden steamships	**Ships:** 1 ironclad, 3 gunboats
LOSSES	
Men: 315 **Ships:** 1 ironclad	**Men:** 35 casualties, 123 captured **Ships:** 1 ironclad and 2 gunboats captured

By the fourth year of the Civil War, Mobile, Alabama, was one of only two Confederate ports still successfully challenging the Union naval blockade (the other being Savannah, Georgia). In August 1864 Union forces under Admiral David Farragut sought to close this avenue for blockade-runners by taking control of Mobile Bay.

As the fog lifted around 6:00 a.m. on August 5, Farragut's squadron crossed the bar at the entrance to the bay on the flood tide. His four armored monitors led the way, steaming to starboard of his wooden ships to protect them from the fire of Fort Morgan's batteries. Meanwhile, Confederate admiral Franklin Buchanan brought *Tennessee* (an unwieldy ironclad ram) and three unarmored gunboats up to block the channel into the bay. The Union ironclads began a vigorous exchange of fire with Fort Morgan, creating such smoke that Farragut had to climb the mainmast of his flagship, the screw-sloop *Hartford*, to see what was happening.

The leading Union monitor was Commander Tunis Craven's *Tecumseh*. As Buchanan's ships opened fire from ahead, Craven maneuvered to engage *Tennessee*. Veering to port, *Tecumseh* struck a mine (or "torpedo"), triggering a massive explosion. The monitor capsized and sank, taking Craven and more than 90 of the crew to the bottom. For a moment the Union squadron came to a halt under the fire of the fort's guns, as captains hesitated to press forward for fear of mines. Farragut's resolve saved the day. With the famous cry "Damn the torpedoes! Full speed ahead!" the Union admiral ordered his flagship forward through the mined channel, followed without further loss by the rest of the squadron.

Although facing overwhelming odds, Buchanan gallantly refused to accept defeat. *Tennessee*'s guns did a great deal of damage to Union ships and

Battle of the ironclads
Commander David G. Farragut (far right) stands in the rigging of his sloop-of-war *Hartford*. In the foreground, a gun crew readies a Dahlgren gun to fire point-blank at a Confederate ironclad.